

1258-IMM498-02: PSYCHOLOGY OF ETHICS

Reflection Paper: Should Marketing to Children Be Banned?

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Introduction and Context:

To understand the ethical debate around marketing to children, we have to examine how children actually navigate the market. With kids under 12 spending \$11 billion+ annually (4), it is important to note that they are not just passive observers; they possess a unique influence known as "Pester Power." This is the tendency for children to unrelentingly request advertised items, effectively weaponizing their desires against their parents to drive household spending. According to marketing research, children influence 97% of breakfast choices and 98% of family entertainment choices (8). However, there is still a question of whether leveraging this power is ethical, given a child's developmental vulnerabilities.

Summary of Arguments:

The primary argument for the "Pro-Ban" side relies on the psychological concept of cognitive defense, specifically the idea of defenselessness. The APA Task Force on Advertising and Children found that children under the age of eight lack the cognitive development to understand "persuasive intent", meaning they view commercials as unbiased facts rather than sales pitches (1). Proponents argue that because children cannot mentally defend themselves against this manipulation, marketing to them is simply unfair.

The World Health Organization has established a direct link between exposure to ads and childhood obesity. Among the 13,000-30,000 ads children see each year (7), they see 12 food ads a day. 84% of these ads viewed by children are for products high in fat, sugar, or sodium (9). The argument here is simple: marketing shapes taste preferences that lead to long-term physical harm. Another physical harm is the use of bright colors and characters on drugs and alcohol, mimicking candy in a way that tricks children (3).

On the "Con" side (Anti-Ban), the main argument is economic. As the Information Technology & Innovation Foundation argues, advertising revenue funds the "free" internet content that children rely on, such as YouTube Kids and educational apps (5). This can actually be a good thing for families, as these costs allow platforms to remain free rather than adopt subscription/"pay-to-play" models, lessening the "Digital Divide," or the lack of access to these educational and learning resources for lower-income families. Furthermore, opponents argue that parents, not the government, should be the ultimate gatekeepers of what their children see, citing the availability of parental controls and the First Amendment right of businesses to advertise legal products (5).

Connection to Course Concepts

This debate highlights a major conflict between **Stakeholders** (6). Advertisers prioritize profit and survival in a competitive market, while parents prioritize their child's health/well-being, as well as financial needs. The child, as the most vulnerable stakeholder, is caught in the middle.

We can also look at this through the lens of **Locus of Control** (6). The "Anti-Ban" argument relies on an Internal Locus of Control, suggesting that parents have the power and responsibility to

filter what their kids see. However, the "Pro-Ban" side argues that modern "Dark Patterns" in game design (manipulative features that trick users) make it impossible for parents to exercise full control, shifting the responsibility back to the state for external regulation (2).

Personal Opinion

If I had to choose between a strict "Pro" or "Con" stance, I would opt for a middle ground of heightened restrictions. I do not believe a total ban is realistic because of the economic damage it would do to free access, but the current system is predatory.

I would support regulations similar to those implemented in the UK, such as the "9pm Watershed" rule, which bans high-fat, salt, and sugar (HFSS) food advertising on TV before 9:00 PM to protect children during their peak viewing times. I also believe in no ads in children's TV channels and programs, so the content can be focused on, and TV shows would not be structured around ad breaks.

Beyond TV, apps should be screened for gambling and dark patterns, and the results should be listed wherever they are downloaded. If more people knew what to look for, I feel these platforms would become less popular and be labelled as ads, forcing companies to shift their focus from quantity to quality in sales.

References

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